



Civic Meeting Report

County Council Budget Hearings 2025, Wednesday September 3rd Afternoon Session

Meeting Metadata	Details
Video Recording	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=R-VSV1HRI6w
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Comprehensive Municipal Meeting Report

Meeting: Delaware County Council (Budget Review Sessions)

Date & Time: August 26<U+2013>27, 2025 (Reflected in Transcript)

Document Type: Official Meeting Summary & Civic Analysis

Executive Overview

This report provides a structured chronological summary of the municipal budget review sessions. The County Council systematically evaluated departmental budgets across multiple funds, focusing heavily on salary structures, rising health care and medical costs in public safety, fixed utility commitments (including a controversial natural gas aggregation contract), and the structural gap left by state funding shifts.

1. Meeting Identification & Attendance

- **Call to Order:** The presiding officers convened the regular budget review proceedings to analyze and adjust departmental requests for the upcoming fiscal year.

- **Attendance:** Council members, department heads, and constitutional officers (including the Sheriff, Prosecutor, Clerk, Public Defender, Health Department Director, and 911 Communications Director) participated in the deliberations.
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2. Substantive Business & Board Action (Chronological Review)

A. Emergency Management Agency (EMA) Budget 00:00:02

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** John (EMA Director)
- **Deliberation Summary:**
 - The council reviewed June 30th budget balances, noting high percentage expenditures in operating supplies, fuel, contractual services, and communications.
 - **Tornado Sirens:** The Director highlighted a critical long-term infrastructure liability: the county maintains 34 tornado sirens (29 managed directly by EMA), which are nearing end-of-life and frequently struck by lightning. Replacement costs roughly \$25,000 to \$35,000 per unit. State grant funding is heavily skewed toward cybersecurity rather than physical warning infrastructure, though the Redevelopment Commission previously assisted with specific replacements. A \$10,000 line item was established for ongoing siren repairs.
 - **Utilities & Grants:** The EMA budget benefits from an annual EMPG salary reimbursement grant of approximately \$64,246. Discussion also covered the Local Emergency Planning Committee (LEPC / "Right to Know") fund, which is driven by industry fees on extremely hazardous substances (EHS).
- **Action & Vote Disposition:** Reviewed and adjusted; balanced within operational constraints.

B. Emergency Medical Services (EMS) Budget 00:10:48

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Mike and Megan (EMS Representatives)
- **Deliberation Summary:**
 - **Educational Incentive Pay:** Utilized near the end of the year as staff complete degree milestones.
 - **Billing & Cost Recovery:** Discussion centered on a flat-rate billing/recovery contract with the *Bluham Company*, which runs two years behind and yields \$35,000 to \$50,000 annually in Medicare/Medicaid reimbursements (costing ~\$5,700).
 - **Utility Crisis (Constellation Energy):** The department faced a major budget crunch due to an automated, auto-renewing natural gas aggregation contract with *Constellation Energy*, which was consuming 60% of their utility budget through unpredictable, frequent multi-dollar deductions. Commissioner Brand reported that

a third-party cost stewardship firm was auditing the contract to determine if the county was paying redundant utility bills.

- **District Assets:** The department maintains a District 6 healthcare coalition mobile hospital/reunification box truck, generating \$5,000 annually via a lease agreement.
- **Internet Infrastructure:** Transitioned four separate residential accounts into a single secure business account with redundancy (cellular backup) to protect secure medication vending machines (morphine/volume storage).
- **Action & Vote Disposition:** Adjusted utility and contractual lines; salaries and benefits reverted to 2025 baseline levels pending final reconciliation.

C. Sheriff's Office & Jail Budgets 00:52:22

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Sheriff Tony Skinner and staff
- **Deliberation Summary:**
 - **Shift & Educational Differentials:** Reviewed shift differential pay (\$500 biannually for qualifying evening/night merit and jail staff) and educational/military incentives.
 - **Pension Fund Status:** The Department of Defense/Police Pension fund balance reached \$24.3 million as of June 30, showing strong investment performance (yielding ~\$1.47M in the first 6 months, exceeding annual payouts). The fund remains underfunded by roughly \$7.5 million, with discussion revolving around minimum versus accelerated catch-up contributions.
 - **Fleet Management:** The regular county budget allots \$52,000 for vehicles (sufficient for ~95% of one car). The fleet is heavily sustained by the Sheriff's commissary fund and the Redevelopment Commission (which supplied 6 Dodge Durangos this year).
 - **Communications & FirstNet:** Staff noted challenges with cellular and radio congestion during major incidents (e.g., the Selma tornado). The department is transitioning to AT&T's *FirstNet* network for dedicated priority coverage.
 - **Jail Medical Costs (QCC Contract):** The "800 lb gorilla." Inmate populations increased from ~250 in the old facility to ~400 in the new jail. The medical provider (*Quality Correctional Care - QCC*) requested an additional 124 hours/week (including site administration and medical-trained personnel) to handle lengthy medication passes and rising acuity, amounting to an increase of \$189,110.
 - **Federal Inmate Revenue:** The jail houses ~55 federal inmates, generating substantial revenue (\$140,000+/month, trending toward ~\$1.6M annually), which helps offset skyrocketing operational costs, though federal transports place a heavy strain on staff.
- **Action & Vote Disposition:** Salaries reverted to 2025 levels; select corporal raises (\$1,000 adjustment) were debated; federal revenue estimates adjusted upward to \$1.3M+; pension contributions addressed via LIT placeholders.

D. Community Corrections Budgets 00:20:06

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Community Corrections Administration
- **Deliberation Summary:**
 - **Project Income:** Project income balances recovered strongly post-COVID, sitting at approximately \$500,000.
 - **Copy Equipment Lease:** Administration plans to migrate off an unfavorable copier arrangement (paying for machine purchase plus per-copy fees) to join the county's LEAP lease contract.
 - **Grants & State Funding:** Reviewed multiple DOC grants (Adult Drug Court, Veterans Treatment Court, Mental Health Court planning grants, and Community Transition Program funds). Grant personnel expenses and benefits are strictly managed against state allocations.
- **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote; balances noted and aligned with grant constraints.

E. Prosecutor's Office Budgets 00:25:05

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Prosecutor Jack and staff
- **Deliberation Summary:**
 - **Deputy Prosecutor Retention Matrix:** The council affirmed the retention matrix adopted the prior year, which successfully recruited experienced prosecutors from neighboring jurisdictions (e.g., Hamilton County).
 - **Litigation Expenses:** Reviewed high-cost professional services, expert witnesses, toxicologists, and video/transcript deposition fees required due to modern evidentiary standards (video witness statements requiring formal transcription).
 - **Pre-Trial Diversion & Fund Utilization:** Discussed shifting certain operational costs (office supplies, specific administrative lines) into user-fee funds (Pre-Trial Diversion) to relieve pressure on the county general fund.
- **Action & Vote Disposition:** A \$10,000 give-back was agreed upon for professional services; baseline salaries maintained with minor adjustments. Approved by Voice Vote.

F. Health Department Budgets 01:13:43

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Jamie (Health Department Director)
- **Deliberation Summary:**
 - **Health First Indiana & State Funding:** The department faces severe fiscal pressure following statewide funding reductions of \$1.9 million across programs. The Director emphasized the necessity of maintaining the baseline budget of ~\$840,000 to preserve state reimbursement eligibility, utilizing rolling carryovers from Health First to extend program lifespans through anticipated state legislative shifts by 2028-2029.
 - **Staffing & Vacancies:** Two Environmental Health Specialist positions are currently vacant; holding them open creates short-term salary savings

(~\$28,000<U+2013>\$30,000) for 2025.

- **School & Vaccine Funds:** Maintained dedicated vaccine administration fee funds and school-health/AED grant lines (CFDA 93.345).
- **Action & Vote Disposition:** Operating supply lines reduced by \$33,050 to baseline; equipment and other supply lines adjusted downward by \$2,000 each. Approved by Voice Vote.

G. Public Defender Budgets 03:50:08

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Sam (Public Defender)
- **Deliberation Summary:**
 - **Staffing & Retention:** Staffing levels remain stable with minimal turnover.
 - **Major Trial & Appellate Costs:** Discussed "Attorney County Employee" and professional services lines, which fund expert testimony, psychological evaluations, and complex multi-day trial fees (mandatory for Level 1 felonies and murder cases meeting State Public Defender Commission reimbursement standards).
 - **Reimbursement Rates:** State reimbursement sits at 40%, with ongoing legislative efforts attempting to push reimbursement toward 50%.
- **Action & Vote Disposition:** Salaries adjusted to baseline; supplemental fund postage and equipment line corrections noted for January appropriation adjustments. Approved by Voice Vote.

H. County Clerk & Election Board Budgets 04:31:05

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Rick (County Clerk)
- **Deliberation Summary:**
 - **Classification Study:** Addressed a classification anomaly for a cross-trained deputy clerk (Deputy Clerk 17), adjusting the position to reflect specialized duties across multiple court/election facets.
 - **Postage & Election Board Expenses:** A significant debate occurred over postage projections (\$150,000 requested in general county lines plus \$75,000 in election board postage) driven by statewide voter list maintenance audits, citizenship verification mailers, and the impending transition to vote centers.
 - **Vote Centers:** The clerk confirmed preparations to transition to vote centers to improve voter convenience, though emphasizing that staffing levels will be maintained to prevent long lines.
- **Action & Vote Disposition:** Postage reduced by \$25,000 in the election board budget; professional services held for further internal review. Approved by Voice Vote.

I. 911 Communications Budget 05:15:07

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Fred (Communications Director)
- **Deliberation Summary:**

- **Staffing & Retention Strategy:** The Director strongly defended the final year of a structured multi-year salary plan, pointing out that dispatchers are reaching competitive benchmarks which have successfully eliminated chronic vacancies (with a new hire filling the final open line).
 - **Call Volume & Staffing Deficits:** Workload studies indicate a need for 8 to 11 additional dispatchers to handle rising call volumes, though fiscal constraints forced the withdrawal of a new position request for this cycle.
 - **Capital Infrastructure:** Noted upcoming capital liabilities, including the replacement of a \$2 million radio system by 2030, which requires strategic savings within the statewide 911 fund.
 - **Fiscal Critique:** The Director delivered a direct critique of local fiscal policy, arguing that historical reluctance to adjust the Local Income Tax (LIT) has forced departments into structural budget crunches.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** New position request removed; salary structure maintained pending final revenue balancing. Approved by Voice Vote.
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3. Open Public Comment / Citizen Forum

- *Note: These budget work sessions focused entirely on departmental presentations, administrative testimony, and council deliberation. No formal citizen forum or open public comment period for general residents occurred during this segment of the meeting transcripts.*
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4. Administrative Updates & Adjournment

- **Schedule Announcements:** The presiding officers noted that remaining departmental reviews (including Commissioner Highway, Human Resources, and other auxiliary funds) would resume the following morning.
 - **Adjournment:** The meeting recessed/adjourned in accordance with the published agenda timeline.
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